

The Fortress on the Hill

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A young soldier and his horse wandered through the outskirts of an evergreen forest. The pine scent filled his lungs and far above them the cloudless sky and joyful sun poked gleefully through the green canopies. Erebus reached into the side of his bulky backpack for a map and carefully unfurled it. “We just need to keep going north,” he said to his steed, patting him gently. “We get to the old fort and then you can have all the hay you want.” The soldier chuckled. He was assigned to an outpost for a potential war and was excited to serve the Inktaill army at last. The trees gradually shifted into open fields dotted with lavenders where a stone fortress sat on a hill in the middle. *Lord, I'm almost there.*

Erebus chucked the reins in excitement and galloped through the purple fields, up the hill, and into a sliding stop to wave a signal frantically. *I'm not the enemy so please don't shoot me with a hundred arrows!* He thought. There was an awkward pause before the iron gates opened. He slid off his stallion and guided it to the stables. *Where is everyone?* Erebus wondered as his horse gobbled up hay. *Wait, I can find the gatekeeper. He can help me.*

His boots thudded heavily on the spiraling stone stairs. Erebus guessed the gatekeeper would be stationed somewhere above the gate. He poked his head into several rooms, making a mental map of this unfamiliar place. *Why did You send me here, Lord?* The smell of rosemary tea wafted through the air. It's coming from the room with the sturdy-looking oak door. He hesitated for a moment before knocking and walking into a sunlit room with windows on three sides.

Two faces turned to Erebus. The older one had a menacing face softened by gentle blue eyes, but the other was about his age with striking familiarity behind those emerald eyes. *I've seen him before.*

The older soldier smiled at him. "You must be the other recruit. Welcome to Fort Opalite," his eyes wrinkled with friendliness. "Come have some tea. I'm Berthram the gatekeeper and I'll teach you both the basic procedures here." Berthram produced a carved wooden cup from a little cupboard and poured warm rosemary tea into it.

I should introduce myself, Erebus thought as he received the warm gift. "Thank you," he started. "My name is Erebus."

"Erebus?" the familiar stranger spoke up. "This is a strange question, but were you at the Obsidian Festival two moons ago?"

Erebus froze. "Yeah I was. Hey, you were that archer trainee, weren't you? The one who shot 6 bullseyes in a row?"

"That's me! Name's Jeconiah," he smiled meekly. "And you almost jousting yourself into a tree, didn't you?"

"Oh, someone saw that." laughed Erebus awkwardly.

Berthram cleared his throat. "Nice to hear you two are well acquainted. Now, shall we get acquainted with the rules?"

The orientation was rather brief, ending with a casual tour throughout the old fortress. Erebus can't help but feel uneasy with how empty the halls are. Most other forts he had seen were bustling with activity where there's always soldiers on duty, training, or spending quality time with each other. But here? Barely a soul. He noticed a similar expression on Jeconiah's face as they walked along the courtyard. "Quick question, where's everyone?" Erebus pointed out.

"Probably busy bickering about last week," Berthram muttered with a disappointed look. He saw the puzzled faces staring back at him and added, "The supply party got lost in the Crystalline Forest for a week since the archers couldn't agree with the vanguards which path was the right one," he shrugged. "And now they blame each other."

Jeconiah glanced at the deserted training courtyard. “That doesn't sound good,” he walked up to a window and gazed at the lavender fields outside. “What if enemies try to raid us in this condition?”

“Well, those almost never happened before,” dismissed Berthram. “Only fools would raid a fortress surrounded by open fields. Besides, it'll settle by the end of the week... It usually does.”

The company walked in silence for a while. Erebus was deep in thought. *Is this why You brought me here? To unite a fortress after a little fight? A war literally might happen any day now!* He prayed silently, *Maker, please guide me through this.*

It's been a day since the recruits settled in. Erebus was assigned chores around the fort whereas Jeconiah was assigned to the watchtower with Ingram, his mentor. *We need to figure out how we can fix this divided fortress situation.* Erebus thought as he polished armor under the setting sun. *Why do I feel like this is urgent?* The dinner bells rang, signaling supper in the dining hall.

The grand hall was the only bustling place in this fortress— especially when supper was served. Erebus scanned the crowd for his friend, finding him waving at a distance. They had agreed to discuss tactics to restore the unity of Fort Opalite. Erebus noticed a distinct divide between the archers and soldiers, both staring belligerently and muttering among themselves. He felt the watchful gaze of the archers and walked past his fellow soldiers who beckoned him to an empty seat. Erebus politely turned down the offer.

“What if we secretly give them cookies and say it's from the other side?” he sat next to Jeconiah.

“Mmmph, great idea,” he said with a mouthful of stew. “But where do we get a hundred cookies?”

“Yeah, that won't work.”

“Maybe group activities like... baking cookies?” Jeconiah smirked. “We'd get two birds with one stone!”

“Now where do we get all that flour? Okay, stop it with the cookies!”

They came up with more crazy ideas as they devoured their warm bean stew, but after longer thinking decided they were too unrealistic. The silver moon rose above the horizon and Jeconiah had to leave for his night shift at the watchtower.

“I'll try talking to the others for now and convince them to set things right. Good luck with your shift!” Erebus bellowed to Jeconiah, who was gearing up and leaving. Soon he was left sitting alone. *Lord, give me the right words to say.* He stood up and approached the rowdy table of soldiers. “Hey Ebony, what're you guys doing?”

“Witnessing the most intense chess battle ever!” His mentor announced, clearing a seat for Erebus. The match was close and the two burly-looking competitors were tense in concentration. Erebus glanced at the archers' table playing a fun-looking game of cards.

“Don't pay attention to those slouchin' archers, kiddo.” Grumbled the scar-faced man sitting across him. “Their incompetence is bad for you.”

“Says the birdbrains who got us lost!” Retorted a bearded archer. A warzone of shouting matches suddenly erupted in the dining hall.

Uh-oh. Lord help! He waved his arms, “Stop! Everyone stop fighting!” but his chants were drowned in the sea of insults. *How do I stop this?* He looked around the chaotic room for something to grab their attention. *I hope Jeconiah's having a better time.* Suddenly the alarm bells rang and silence fell.

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Ingram had left him in charge of the watchtower. *Which is crazy! I just got here yesterday.* Jeconiah breathed in the fresh air and admired the dark hills. *Was that smoke?*

Jeconiah jerked his head towards the window, his eyes scanning the darkness outside. He walked closer with sharp eyes and his bow ready, still eyeing the shadowy hills. There they were! Cloaked figures under the cover of the night sneaking along the dark corners of the walls. He ducked out of sight, heart racing. *I need to warn Berthram!* He rushed down a flight of stairs and sprinted to Berthram's station. With rapid knocks he burst into the gatekeeper's room. "Spies!" he rasped, catching his breath. "Enemies... camping north-west. We... need to warn... others."

Berthram sounded the alarm bells, gathering every soldier and archer into the courtyard. They seemed disgruntled to stand so close to each other.

"Why did you summon us?" An archer questioned. "We don't want anything to do with those *soldiers*." Another shouting match began.

"Enough!" Berthram dismissed. "Enemies were spotted outside these walls. You all must defend this fort together."

They grew silent, worry written on their faces. "Alright, just this once."

"No! Not just this once." Erebus spoke up, pushing his way through the gathering. "Every kingdom divided against itself is brought to desolation." He declared, "And every city or house divided against itself will not stand."

"Are we gonna let past mistakes divide what God has brought together?" Jeconiah challenged. The troops murmured among themselves.

Ebony nodded, "They're right... We fought over something silly." He turned to the archer beside him, bowing sincerely. "I'm sorry." A chain reaction of forgiveness began.

Berthram cleared his throat, "Alright, gear up and stand by your stations." He commanded. "We've got a fortress to defend!"